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Meta to stop selling political ads in the EU from October

In response to the European Union's incoming regulation of political advertising, Meta said on Friday that it will stop selling and showing political ads in the EU from October 27, 2025, calling the legislation's requirements "unworkable," the tech giant [wrote in a blog post](#) that the law, dubbed [Transparency and Targeting of Political Advertising](#) (TTPA), introduces "significant, additional obligations to our processes and systems that create an untenable level of complexity and legal uncertainty for advertisers and platforms operating in the EU."

IMAGE CREDITS: THOMAS FOLLEY/SOPA IMAGES/LIGHTROCKET / GETTY IMAGES
Adopted by the European Commission in 2024, the TTPA mandates companies selling ads to clearly label political advertisements and provide information about their sponsor, the election or referendum they concern, what the ad cost, and what targeting mechanisms were used.

The law also requires that data collected to serve political ads must only be used if the person or entity gives their consent to use it for political advertising, and bans the use of some types of personal data, such as information that could reveal a person's racial or ethnic origin or political opinions, from being used for profiling.

Those requirements seem to be too much for Meta, however, which derives the vast majority of its revenues from advertising. The company said it had consulted with the EU extensively, but came to the

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conclusion that it would either have to alter its services to offer an ad service that “doesn’t work for advertisers or users,” or stop offering such ads altogether.

“Once again, we’re seeing regulatory obligations effectively remove popular products and services from the market, reducing choice and competition,” Meta wrote.

Google, another advertising giant that also [said](#) it would stop selling political ads in the EU by October, raised similar points, arguing that the law brings significant operational challenges and legal uncertainty.

This is the latest of a string of tussles between the EU and Big Tech as the bloc tries to rein in the influence and power of these platforms. Tech companies have been [battling the EU’s AI Act](#), its enforcement of [competition rules](#), [ad-tracking regulation](#), and more.

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Ram is a financial and tech reporter and editor. He covered North American and European M&A, equity, regulatory...

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Report reveals Big Tech’s last minute lobbying to weaken EU rules

Natasha Lomas — 3:01 PM PDT · April 22, 2022

A new report has peeled back the curtain on big

IMAGE CREDITS:

ARTUR WIDAK/NURPHOTO / GETTY IMAGES

tech's frenzied lobbying of European Union lawmakers as they finalize a major series of updates to the bloc's digital rulebook.

It reveals some of the arguments used by tech giants including Apple, Amazon, Google, Meta (Facebook) and Spotify to press their interests behind the scenes in a bid to reshape key components of the EU's Digital Markets Act (DMA) and Digital Services Act (DSA) — targeting areas such as surveillance advertising and access to platform data for researchers — with the clear intent of shielding their processes and business models from measures that could weaken their market power.

The report, which is based on lobbying documents obtained by civil society groups [Corporate Europe Observatory](#) and [Global Witness](#) via freedom of information requests, also highlights how tech giants have ramped up their spending on regional lobbying since the DMA and DSA were proposed back in [December 2020](#) — with the big five collectively spending over €27M (close to \$30M) last year alone.

It concludes with a series of recommendations for how policymakers can better protect the democratic process from undue influence by the best resourced corporate giants.

Spend, spend, spend!

Citing publicly disclosed data, the report shows that Apple has increased its spending on EU lobbying the most — almost doubling how much it's shelling out from €3.5M in 2020 to €6.5M in 2021, meaning it also pulled into the lead among platform peers for total regional lobbying spend last year.

Facebook (Meta) had the next biggest increase, growing the size of its EU lobbying budget from €5.5M in 2020 to €6M in 2021. Google also topped up its outlay from €5.8M in 2020 to €6M. While Amazon and Microsoft both made similar increases in regional spending over this period.

Big Tech boosts EU lobbying

New EU Transparency Register update show that Big Tech firms boosted their EU lobbying in 2021. Their combined lobby spending exceeded 27 million euros.

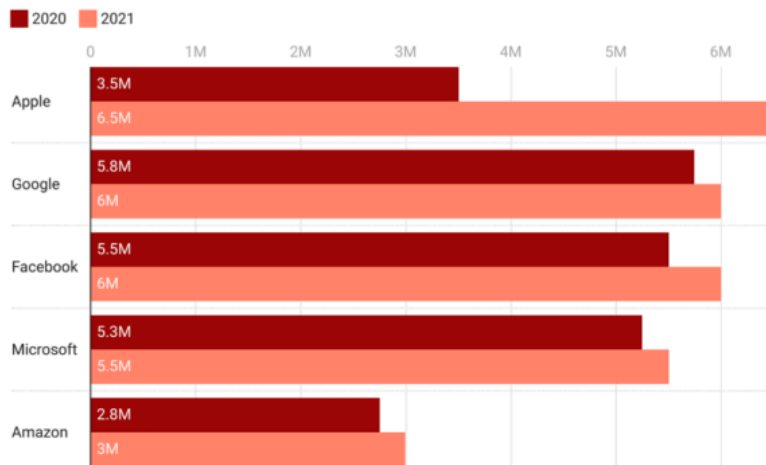


Chart: Corporate Europe Observatory • Source: EU Transparency Register • Created with Datawrapper

IMAGE CREDIT: CORPORATE EUROPE OBSERVATORY

The DMA, which gained political agreement [last month](#), will apply only to the largest and most powerful intermediary platforms — so called “gatekeepers”; a designation that’s likely to apply to the five ‘big spenders’ in the above chart — introducing a set of operational obligations these giants must abide by up-front.

TC

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The pan-EU regulation, which is expected to come into force in October, aims to reboot competition in digital markets dominated by gatekeepers and ensure they remain open and fair.

Its sister regulation — the DSA — applies more broadly, setting rules for all sorts of digital services which are intended to harmonize online approaches to tackling illegal content and products. This means it touches on areas like content moderation, consumer protection and transparency. And while it applies across digital services a subset of so-called “very large online platforms” (aka VLOPs) will be subject to additional oversight under the regulation — meaning that tech giants will face additional DSA compliance hurdles vs smaller players.

At the time of writing the DSA is still pending political agreement — although a deal is expected after Friday’s (April 22) trilogue meeting — so the impact of big tech’s lobbying on EU policymaking should become clearer in the coming days.

So what have tech giants been spending their millions on lobbying for as EU lawmakers finalize the DSA and DMA?

Read on for a breakdown of their focus areas from the report...

Surveillance advertising

One major target for Big Tech lobbyists, per the report, has been around surveillance advertising as tech giants marshalled their millions to block off an

attempt to get an outright ban on tracking-based advertising into EU legislation.

They succeeded in that goal as an [earlier push by some MEPs for an outright ban](#) did not gain full backing of the parliament so did not make it into the trilogue discussions. But the European Parliament did vote to incorporate limits on tracking ads into both the [DSA](#) and the [DMA](#) — with MEPs backing a ban on processing of minors’ data for targeting ads and a ban on use of sensitive categories of personal data.

However the Council position diverged from parliament, toeing closer to the Commission’s original proposal — which had merely suggested ads transparency requirements — so tech giants sought to exploit this to try to water down restrictions on tracking ads, per the report.

[Inside a European push to outlaw creepy ads](#)

Documents obtained for the report show that Google directly lobbied the Commission in a series of high level meetings with top commissioners between November and early January in which the adtech giant raised concerns about the European Parliament’s proposals on advertising — suggesting limits on trackings would be detrimental to SMEs and harm news publishers.

“This marked a continuation of Google and Facebook’s strategy throughout the whole discussion on new digital regulations — trying to reframe it away from Big Tech’s immense profits and business model and to instead hype up potential negative impacts for smaller businesses and consumers,” the report notes. “As Google’s [leaked lobbying strategy](#) showed, one of its priorities was to focus the discussion on the costs to the economy and consumers.”

Between January to the end of March, lobby documents show that Google remained in frequent contact with the Swedish government — arguing on four different occasions against Parliament’s proposal to ban advertising targeted at minors and other limits, per the report. “Their recommendation to national governments was to ‘support the Council / Commission position (i.e. no restraints on targeted ads)’. Google argued ‘that the DSA is not the right forum to deal with these issues’,” it adds.

There’s a special irony here given [Google also led big tech lobbying efforts to delay an update to the bloc’s ePrivacy rules](#) — which explicitly cover tracking technologies like cookies. That update remains stalled even now (the Commission proposal was presented all the way back in January 2017!). So if the tech giant were to have its way there would, it seems, be no ‘appropriate’ legal forum to rein in its surveillance ads empire. Funny that! 🙄

But as it turns out, EU lawmakers in the Council and Parliament were able to agree — through the trilogue process — on including limits to tracking ads.

At least that was the position announced last month, at the moment of [political agreement on the DMA](#).

At the time of writing the Commission is signalling that limits on targeting advertising will be included in the DSA, with internal market commissioner, Thierry Breton, including a ban on targeted advertising to children or based on sensitive data in a [tweet storm](#) highlighting “10 things you need to know” about the regulation, for example...

6 Ban on targeted advertising for children 🚫

More [#protection](#) against targeted advertising

aimed at children — or based on sensitive data. [#DSA](#)

— Thierry Breton (@ThierryBreton) [April 22, 2022](#)

Under the political deal reached between EU co-legislators last month, the DMA requires gatekeepers to gain explicit consent from users to combine their personal data for advertising.

But the French presidency of the Council also said then that they had agreed complementary provisions to limit tracking ads would *also* be included in the text of the DSA (still to be agreed via trilogue) — signalling that the parliament’s goal of limits on processing children’s data for ads or using sensitive data for ads would make it into EU law.

So what did Google’s lobbyists do next? According to the report, the tech giant continued pushing against any/all limits on surveillance ads — but also evolved the lobbying tactic, by suggesting to Member States governments ways in which restrictions could be watered down in the final text to limit their impact on its ability to track and target web users.

“On 22 March 2022, the day of the final DMA trilogue, Google sent the Swedish government its thoughts for future trilogue meetings,” notes the report.

“Google’s positions reflected the up to date state of the ongoing discussions. Google continued to oppose concrete new proposals regarding user consent to tracking and banning the use of sensitive data for advertising. Perhaps more interesting though, Google now seemed to understand that likely there would be some new limits to targeted advertising. So Google offered suggestions about how these should be drafted: the ban on targeting minors should be limited to ‘known minors’ and behaviour advertising should be defined as the use of individual profiling.”

As the report points out, Google’s fall back positions here are no accident — given that the tech giant has been working for several years to retool its tracking apparatus — under its [so-called Privacy Sandbox plan](#) — which proposes to switch from individual-level tracking and targeting to cohort or (now) [topic-based targeting](#) which will continue to subject web users to behavioral targeting just now putting them into buckets of eyeballs, not solo pairs.

So — to spell it out — if EU lawmakers were to limit the definition of behavioral advertising as Google suggests it could simply circumvent any limits on its flavor of behavioral advertising by saying it does not target individuals ergo the legal restriction simply doesn’t apply.

[Digging into Google’s push to freeze ePrivacy](#)

Similarly, a final text that would ban advertising to “known minors” would allow Google to claim it does not *know* the age of users who are not logged into its services (and potentially even users who are logged in as it does not explicitly age verify users) — again avoiding the need to restrict its behavioral targeting by default across most services (barring any it directly targets at children, such as YouTube kids).

Per the report, Google’s lobbyists didn’t stop there. They also sought to water down ad transparency requirements — pushing back against proposals that would allow users to know the criteria used to target them specifically, including when ads were targeted at kids and — in “detailed suggestions” to national governments — proposed that they should “seek to delete the obligation to disclose the criteria used for targeting, even when ads target vulnerable people like children”.

“The documents show Google taking a central position lobbying against limits to surveillance ads,”

the report adds. “But they weren’t alone. Facebook, and other European companies [including Spotify] and publishers also resorted to trying to persuade national governments to oppose the Parliament’s position.”

Another big target for Big Tech tech lobbying was around data access for NGOs and public scrutiny...

Public scrutiny

On this issue, which is core to the DSA’s ability to deliver on the goal of ramping up accountability around major platforms, the report details particular moves by Spotify and Google to limit how much access external researchers can gain to platform data — such as to carry out research into the societal impact of recommender algorithms.

Civil society groups have been pushing to strengthen the Commission proposal in this area — to increase external scrutiny of VLOPs by forcing them to give access to data on algorithmic content ranking systems to vetted external researchers so they can study their function.

But Spotify and Google have been busy pushing back against closer scrutiny of how their AIs rank and recommend content to users, per the report.

“The world’s biggest music streaming service didn’t want the transparency requirements to include detailed lists of parameters, as was introduced by the Parliament. On the other hand, it welcome the Parliament’s last-minute introduction of exceptions to recommender transparency, including the protection of intellectual property and trade secrets,” runs one section on Spotify’s lobbying.

“In March this year, Spotify followed up to add its comments ‘regarding the latest compromise proposals on Recommender Systems’. The

company supported the ‘evolution of the text’ regarding recommender transparency and welcomed ‘a clarification in a Recital that these rules do not prejudice IP [intellectual property] rights and trade secrets’,” it adds.

Google, meanwhile, was lobbying Member State governments to limit data access for public authorities and vetted researchers to urgent health threats. So in this scenario Europeans might have to wait for the next pandemic to get external scrutiny of YouTube’s recommender engine!

Where the DSA will actually end up on this issue isn’t clear at the time of writing.

Google also questioned whether non-profits organizations should get data — seeking to spread fear that this could put “user data and privacy and confidentiality of information at risk”, according to lobbying documents obtained for the report.

“The company asked national governments to oppose the Parliament’s position and instead support the Council’s mandate. Taken all together, Google’s suggestions would make external scrutiny of the ways in which services like Youtube amplify or de-prioritise content nearly impossible,” it adds.

The report also reveals Google opposed proposals that would require platforms to “make the information on the main parameters for recommender systems and the functionality to opt-out from personalised recommendations directly accessible from the content itself” — presumably because that would make it too easy for users to figure out how to turn off unwanted content recommendations.

[Privacy not a blocker for ‘meaningful’ research access to platform data, says report](#)

‘DMA? Er, just give us a chance to explain first...’

On the DMA, Google, Amazon, Apple and Facebook were all spotted in documents obtained for the report trying to soften the proposal during its last stage.

Apple, for example, brought its (now) [familiar argument against moves to force it to open up its App Store](#) and mobile OS, such as by allowing sideloading of apps or other types of interoperability, to discussion tables in the region.

“The company’s main argument was that increasing data access, sideloading and interoperability would reduce user privacy and security,” the report notes, going on to conclude: “While Apple could not successfully stop interoperability and sideloading entirely, the final text does introduce a security safeguard, which will enable the company to try to justify not complying with these obligations.”

It also highlights one particular strand of collective lobbying by Big Tech targeting the DMA that looks intended to enable a repeat show of an oft used tactic against enforcement of existing EU laws which threaten how they like to operate — such as the GDPR (General Data Protection Regulation). This tactic boils down to one word: Delay.

Per the report:

“[T]he top level message from the Big Tech companies to policy-makers regarding the DMA was the same across the board: Big Tech wanted to build a dialogue between the DMA’s regulator — the European Commission — and the companies covered by it — the gatekeepers, into the text and the regulatory approach.

“They brought this wish up consistently at the high level meetings, such as the December meeting between Google and [Margrethe] Vestager’s cabinet. There Google said that regarding the DMA their ‘core argument towards the Parliament was the need for regulatory dialogue and the opportunity to individually justify certain practices’. Google repeated the same message to Breton’s cabinet in January — ‘Proper regulatory dialogue is important to ensure the enforcement of the DMA’.

“On the very same day, Nick Clegg, Facebook’s head lobbyist, told Commissioner [Didier] Reynders, that for Facebook ‘it would be helpful to have the possibility of having a dialogue with regulators on questions concerning compliance’.

“Amazon, in turn, told the Swedish government that it was ‘more comfortable with content of the Council compromise proposal than with the European Parliament’s amendments.’ The company also raised concerns that specific measures had been moved from Article 6 to Article 5, which would mean they would be automatically applicable and not dependent on a regulatory dialogue.”

Thing is, the whole point of the DMA is to bring in an ex ante competition regime for the bloc — via a set of ‘dos and don’ts’ that are supposed to apply up front for companies designated as gatekeepers, i.e. rather than antitrust authorities having to do the slow and painstaking work of building a case against a particular abusive behavior *while the market suffers*.

But there is — potentially — a sliver of wiggle room, at least for obligations set out in Article 6 of the DMA. For those requirements, the regulation allows for a dialogue between the Commission and relevant companies over how best to comply.

Which, well, sounds like it could be spun into delay heaven.

The report summarizes the main aim of Big Tech's lobby campaign against the DMA as being to "expand this dialogue as much as possible", with Corporate Europe Observatory noting it fingered this as a key priority for Facebook, Google and Apple since last summer. It also quotes another lobby transparency group, [Lobbycontrol](#), which has argued that Big Tech's aim here is to "gain time — and first of all an entrance point for challenging the DMA's obligations."

[Facebook's lead EU privacy supervisor hit with corruption complaint](#)

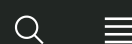
The painstakingly slow '[regulatory dialogue](#)' which Facebook and other tech giants have managed to establish with their lead EU privacy regulator — Ireland's Data Protection Commission — since (and, indeed, even before) the GDPR came into force in 2018, enabling them to successfully delay enforcement despite multiple open investigations into a variety of aspects of their businesses, is likely providing Clegg & co with plentiful inspiration for the sort of friction-filled conversation they want signed off and baked into the DMA to create a legally viable 'back and forth' that lets them delay actually changing abusive practices for as long as humanly possible.

It's not yet clear how successful the tech giants have been in this regard.

However the Commission has, in recent weeks, been spotted making some concerning noises on the topic of DMA enforcement to anyone who actually wants to see regulators crack down on Big Tech, as consumer protection experts have observed...

I cannot believe that the Commission talks so lightly about [#DMA](#) enforcement... it's the Commission's kitchen; it will take time to implement; we don't have resources etc. Seriously people? Why on earth did the legislator (and everybody else behind) work so hard to get this law?

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obligations in the DMA. Earlier this month, the Irish Council for Civil Liberties (ICCL) drew together signatures from a long list of competition and privacy experts to [a letter](#) that warns of “a severe flaw in Article 5(1)a of the latest DMA text” which they suggest will “help Big Tech firms undermine data protection and competition”.

The concern is that gatekeepers will continue to evade the GDPR’s purpose limitation principle by bundling consent for combining user data across multiple services into a single opt-in — thereby making it harder for users to deny — which is essentially how adtech giants like Facebook have evaded existing EU regulations, continuing to track and target web users in the region despite the GDPR’s requirement for unbundled consent (Facebook does not offer an opt out of behavioral advertising; to use its service you have to ‘agree’ to being profiled for ads).

Let's make sure, [@Andreas_Schwab](#), 5(1)a [#DMA](#) closes the loophole for gatekeepers to combine data across all their many services and businesses whenever the user agrees to a single, all-embracing opt-in, undermining the very objectives of the DMA <https://t.co/ZDDeEmb6K2>

— Angela Mills Wade (@epc_angela) [April 20, 2022](#)

The parliament's rapporteur on the DMA file, MEP Andreas Schwab, has rejected the concern in recent days — [suggesting](#) that the DMA does not change the GDPR. And indeed, in a letter responding to the ICCL which we've reviewed, that "the consent requirement under the DMA builds on the GDPR consent". He has also claimed there's "no need to fear circumvention" because the Commission will be in charge of enforcement. Aka, no more forum shopping.

However signatories to the letter continue to warn that gaps in GDPR enforcement create a problem for effectively enforcing the DMA — unless the Commission acts quickly to provide guidance and bring cases.

Collective concern is [#GDPR](#) is not enforced today. So indeed now falls on Commission to be very clear about how it will require [#GDPR](#) rules to be met in practice as part of [#DMA](#) compliance. There's a major gap in enforcement to be filled, need guidance & cases soon [@johnnyryan](#)

— Cristina Caffarra (@Caffar3Cristina) [April 20, 2022](#)

"Gatekeepers will try to use the ambiguity to their advantage," warns the ICCL's Johnny Ryan. "It is essential that the Commission issues quick and clear guidance and enforcement decisions to stop that."

Structural weakness?

How EU lawmaking is structured means the Commission's legislative proposals are typically modified, via a co-legislative process, which loops in the (directly elected) European Parliament and Member States' national government representatives, via the European Council — which together amend, vote and negotiate to try to reach a compromise on the final details of the law.

This means that there are, at least from one perspective, multiple point at which lobbyists can seek to influence — or indeed block — EU policymaking.

This starts with the Commission itself, as the EU's executive body drafts and thus frames legislative proposals; moving on to MEPs who play a key role by voting for amendments and to set the parliament's negotiating position (typically prefigured via committee vote/s); and extending to Member States' governments which are represented on the Council and lead the so-called trilogue negotiations with the Parliament and Commission to seek a compromise via a rotating presidency structure that sees one Member State (currently France) responsible for producing compromise texts on behalf of the Council.

So, in short, it's a lobbyists' picnic!

[US giants top tech industry's \\$100M+ a year lobbying blitz in EU](#)

The latter stage trilogue negotiations are especially problematic, being conducted entirely behind closed doors — thereby reducing transparency on how exactly policy is being reshaped, as the report underlines:

“This process is one of the most secretive stages of EU policy-making, held entirely behind closed doors and with nearly no public access to the discussions. The EU Institutions have argued that this secrecy is

needed in part to prevent lobbying pressure on the policy-makers.

“New lobby documents obtained from the European Commission and the Swedish government via freedom of information requests show that intense corporate lobbying is happening regardless of the lack of transparency.”

The details that the civil society groups were able to glean on big tech’s lobbying around the DMA and DSA are only partial, as the report notes that responses to freedom of information requests varied.

However they say the documents they did obtain showed that tech giants like Google continued to target the trilogue process even after the Council had agreed its negotiating positions — meaning they are shown trying to grasp a very last minute, non-transparent opportunity to favorably water down measures that could shrink their market power.

“We can now confirm that corporate lobbying of EU capitals continues even after the Council agrees its positions and starts trilogue negotiations with the Parliament and Commission,” the report authors write. “While only Sweden gave us extensive access to these documents, we can expect that all EU governments must be on the receiving end of similar lobby efforts.”

“The lobby documents also reveal that Google remained in frequent contact with the Swedish government from January to the end of March (the time when we placed our freedom of information request). During this period, the tech giant would send in analysis of the difference positions, adding the company’s own analysis, and all the while replicating the EU Institutional format of documents with four columns,” they go on. “As the discussions

went on behind closed doors, Google pitched in with ‘specific language on articles currently discussed’ and suggested ‘concrete amendments’, showing a strikingly live knowledge of what was happening in the negotiation process.”

According to the report, Google, Apple, Amazon and Facebook — alongside European firms such as Spotify and the copyright industry — actively sought to influence the trilogues themselves, meaning they were trying to exert influence during the least transparent point of the co-legislative process.

The lobbying tactics they are reported to have used included:

- pitting the EU Institutions against one another;

- becoming more technical and offering amendments to the text;

- using meetings to gain access to information that was not available to the public;

- going high level: bringing in the CEOs to meet Commissioners, inviting them to off the record dinners.

Corporate Europe Observatory and Global Witness argue that this evidence of lobbying taking place during trilogues “shows how the lack of transparency benefits big corporate lobbies and adds weight to the urgency of finally opening the trilogues process up to the public” — further suggesting: “This secrecy means that only the well-resourced and well-connected lobbying actors can follow and intervene in trilogues, and excludes citizens from crucial discussions that will have an impact on their lives.”

“National governments have a say in EU policy-making via the Council. This is often referred to as the EU’s ‘black box’, as it is difficult for citizens to

know who is lobbying their national government on EU policies, or even what position their national government takes in the Council. This approach, combined with the fact that lobbying at member state level requires massive resources and good connections, creates the conditions for undue corporate influence,” they add.

The report makes a series of recommendations to protect EU policymaking against undue influence by the most well-resourced lobbyists, based on the NGOs’ tracking and analysis of the DSA and DMA process since the drafting stages.

Its suggestions include shedding light into the trilogues by publishing an up-to-date calendar of meetings, including summary agendas, and proactively publishing the four-column document (which details co-legislator positions and amendments) on a rolling basis; boosting transparency and democratic accountability at the Member State and Council level including by requiring disclosure of each country’s position; putting limits on one-to-one lobby meetings and replacing them with public hearings as much as possible; and requiring EU institutions to proactively seek out those who have less resources, such as SMEs, independent academics, civil society and community groups.

Other recommendations include beefing up the existing [EU Transparency Register](#) to improve transparency on lobbying; putting in place proper funding transparency requirements that mandate think tanks and other organisations to reveal their funding sources; strengthening ethics rules to block the revolving door between EU institutions and Big Tech firms and establishing an independent ethics committee which can launch investigations and implement sanctions.

The report authors also urge EU officials and policymakers to be sceptical of those lobbying them — writing that they “should question their funding sources, check their information and data sources and denounce any type of wrongdoing or non-transparent/unethical lobbying they encounter”.

They also recommend they should not attend or participate in events or debates that are closed to the public, held under Chatham House rules, or that do not disclose their sponsorship.

[How Europe has expanded its bid to disrupt Big Tech](#)

[Understanding Europe’s big push to rewrite the digital rulebook](#)

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Natasha Lomas

Senior Reporter | X in

Natasha was a senior reporter for TechCrunch, from September 2012 to April 2025, based in Europe. She joine...

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Europe dials up pressure on tech giants over election security

Natasha Lomas — 7:27 AM PST · December 5, 2018

IMAGE CREDITS: [BLABLO101](#)

The European Union has announced a package of measures intended to step up efforts and pressure

on tech giants to combat democracy-denying disinformation ahead of the EU parliament elections next May.

The European Commission [Action Plan](#), which was presented at a press briefing earlier today, has four areas of focus: 1) Improving detection of disinformation; 2) Greater co-ordination across EU Member States, including by sharing alerts about threats; 3) Increased pressure on online platforms, including to increase transparency around political ads and purge fake accounts; and 4) raising awareness and critical thinking among EU citizens.

The Commission says 67% of EU citizens are worried about their personal data being used for political targeting, and 80% want improved transparency around how much political parties spend to run campaigns on social media.

And it warned today that it wants to see rapid action from online platforms to deliver on pledges they've already made to fight fake news and election interference.

The EC's plan follows a voluntary Code of Practice launched [two months ago](#), which signed up tech giants including Facebook, Google and Twitter, along with some ad industry players, to some fairly fuzzy commitments to combat the spread of so-called 'fake news'.

They also agreed to hike transparency around political advertising. But efforts so far remain piecemeal, with — for example — no EU-wide roll out of Facebook's political ads disclosure system.

Facebook has only launched political ad identification checks plus an archive library of ads in the US, Brazil and the UK so far, leaving the rest of the world to rely on the more limited 'view ads' functionality that it has rolled out globally.

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The EC said it will be stepping up its monitoring of platforms' efforts to combat election interference — with the new plan including “continuous” monitoring.

This will take the form of monthly progress reports, starting with a Commission progress report in January and then monthly reports thereafter (against what it slated as “very specific targets”) to ensure signatories are actually purging and disincentivizing bad actors and inauthentic content from their platform, not just saying they're going to.

As we reported in [September](#) the Code of Practice looked to be a pretty dilute first effort. But ongoing progress reports could at least help concentrate minds — coupled with the ongoing threat of EU-wide legislation if platforms fail to effectively self-regulate.

Digital economy and society commissioner Mariya Gabriel said the EC would have “measurable and visible results very soon”, warning platforms: “We

need greater transparency, greater responsibility both on the content, as well as the political approach.”

Security union commissioner, Julian King, came in even harder on tech firms — warning that the EC wants to see “real progress” from here on in.

“We need to see the Internet platforms step up and make some real progress on their commitments. This is stuff that we believe the platforms can and need to do now,” he said, accusing them of “excuses” and “foot-dragging”.

“The risks are real. We need to see urgent improvement in how adverts are placed,” he continued. “Greater transparency around sponsored content. Fake accounts rapidly and effectively identified and deleted.”

King pointed out Facebook admits that between 3% and 4% of its entire user-base is fake.

“That is somewhere between 60M and 90M fake accounts,” he continued. “And some of those accounts are the most active accounts. A recent study found that 80% of the Twitter accounts that spread disinformation during the 2016 US election are still active today — publishing more than a million tweets a day. So we’ve got to get serious about this stuff.”

Twitter declined to comment on today’s developments but a spokesperson told us its “number one priority is improving the health of the public conversation”.

“Tackling co-ordinated disinformation campaigns is a key component of this. Disinformation is a complex, societal issue which merits a societal response,” Twitter’s statement said. “For our part, we are already working with our industry partners,

Governments, academics and a range of civil society actors to develop collaborative solutions that have a meaningful impact for citizens. For example, Twitter recently announced a global partnership with UNESCO on media and information literacy to help equip citizens with the skills they need to critically analyse content they are engaging with online.”

We’ve also reached out to Facebook and Google for comment on the Commission plan.

King went on to press for “clearer rules around bots”, saying he would personally favor a ban on political content being “disseminated by machines”.

The Code of Practice does include a commitment to address both fake accounts and online bots, and “establish clear marking systems and rules for bots to ensure their activities cannot be confused with human interactions”. And Twitter has [previously said](#) it’s considering labelling bots; albeit with the caveat “as far as we can detect them”.

But action is still lacking.

“We need rapid corrections, which are given the same prominence and circulation as the original fake news. We need more effective promotion of alternative narratives. And we need to see overall greater clarity around how the algorithms are working,” King continued, banging the drum for algorithmic accountability.

“All of this should be subject to independent oversight and audit,” he added, suggesting the self-regulation leash here will be a very short one.

He said the Commission will make a “comprehensive assessment” of how the Code is working next year, warning: “If the necessary progress is not made we will not hesitate to

reconsider our options — including, eventually, regulation.”

“We need to be honest about the risks, we need to be ready to act. We can’t afford an Internet that is the wild west where anything goes, so we won’t allow it,” he concluded.

Commissioner Vera Jourova also attended the briefing and used her time at the podium to press platforms to “immediately guarantee the transparency of political advertising”.

“This is a quick fix that is necessary and urgent,” she said. “It includes properly checking and clearly indicating who is behind online advertisement and who paid for it.”

In Spain regional elections took place in Andalusia on Sunday and — as noted above — while Facebook has launched a political ad authentication process and ad archive library in the US and the UK, the company confirmed to us that such a system was not up and running in Spain in time for that regional European election.

In the vote in Andalusia a tiny Far Right party, Vox, [broke pollsters’ predictions](#) to take twelve seats in the parliament — a first since the country’s return to democracy after the death of the dictator Francisco Franco in 1975.

Zooming in on election security risks, Jourova warned that “large-scale organized disinformation campaigns” have become “extremely efficient and spread with the speed of light” online. She also warned that non-transparent ads “will be massively used to influence opinions” in the run up to the EU elections.

Hence the pressing need for a transparency guarantee.

“When we allow the machines to massively influence free decisions of democracy I think that we have appeared in a bad science fiction,” she added. “The electoral campaign should be the competition of ideas, not the competition of dirty money, dirty methods, and hidden advertising where the people are not informed and don’t have a clue that they are influenced by some hidden powers.”

Jourova urged Member States to update their election laws so existing requirements on traditional media to observe a pre-election period also apply online.

“We all have roles to play, not only Member States, also social media platforms, but also traditional political parties. [They] need to make public the information on their expenditure for online activities as well as information on any targeting criteria used,” she concluded.

A report by the UK’s DCMS committee, which has been running an enquiry into online disinformation for the best part of this year, made similar recommendations in its [preliminary report this summer](#).

Though the committee also went further — calling for a levy on social media to defend democracy. Albeit, the [UK government did not leap into the recommended actions](#).

Also speaking at today’s presser, EC VP, Andrus Ansip, warned of the ongoing disinformation threat from Russia but said the EU does not intend to respond to the threat from propaganda outlets like RT, Sputnik and IRA troll farms by creating its own pro-EU propaganda machine.

Rather he said the plan is to focus efforts on accelerating collaboration and knowledge-sharing

to improve detection and indeed debunking of disinformation campaigns.

“We need to work together and co-ordinate our efforts — in a European way, protecting our freedoms,” he said, adding that the plan sets out “how to fight back against the relentless propaganda and information weaponizing used against our democracies”.

Under the action plan, the budget of the [European External Action Service](#) (EEAS) — which bills itself as the EU’s diplomatic service — will more than double next year, to €5M, with the additional funds intended for strategic comms to “address disinformation and raise awareness about its adverse impact”, including beefing up headcount.

“This will help them to use new tools and technologies to fight disinformation,” Ansip suggested.

Another new measure announced today is a dedicated Rapid Alert System which the EC says will facilitate “the sharing of data and assessments of disinformation campaigns and to provide alerts on disinformation threats in real time”, with knowledge-sharing flowing between EU institutions and Member States.

The EC also says it will boost resource for national multidisciplinary teams of independent fact-checkers and researchers to detect and expose disinformation campaigns across social networks — working towards establishing a European network of fact-checkers.

“Their work is absolutely vital in order to combat disinformation,” said Gabriel, adding: “This is very much in line with our principles of pluralism of the media and freedom of expression.”

Investments will also go towards supporting media education and critical awareness, with Gabriel noting that the Commission will to run a European media education week, next March, to draw attention to the issue and gather ideas.

She said the overarching aim is to “give our citizens a whole array of tools that they can use to make a free choice”.

“It’s high time we give greater visibility to this problem because we face this on a day to day basis. We want to provide solutions — so we really need a bottom up approach,” she added. “It’s not up to the Commission to say what sort of initiatives should be adopted; we need to give stakeholders and citizens their possibility to share best practices.”

This report was updated with a correction to include Brazil in the list of countries where Facebook had launched a system for confirming the identity of political advertisers. The other two countries were correctly stated as the US and the UK. Facebook has also since [launched](#) an identity check for political advertisers in India

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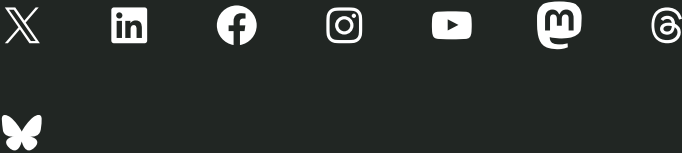
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Natasha was a senior reporter for TechCrunch, from September 2012 to April 2025, based in Europe. She joine...

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